

# SFPA Spring 2026 City Championship

Title Odds — Tournament Projection

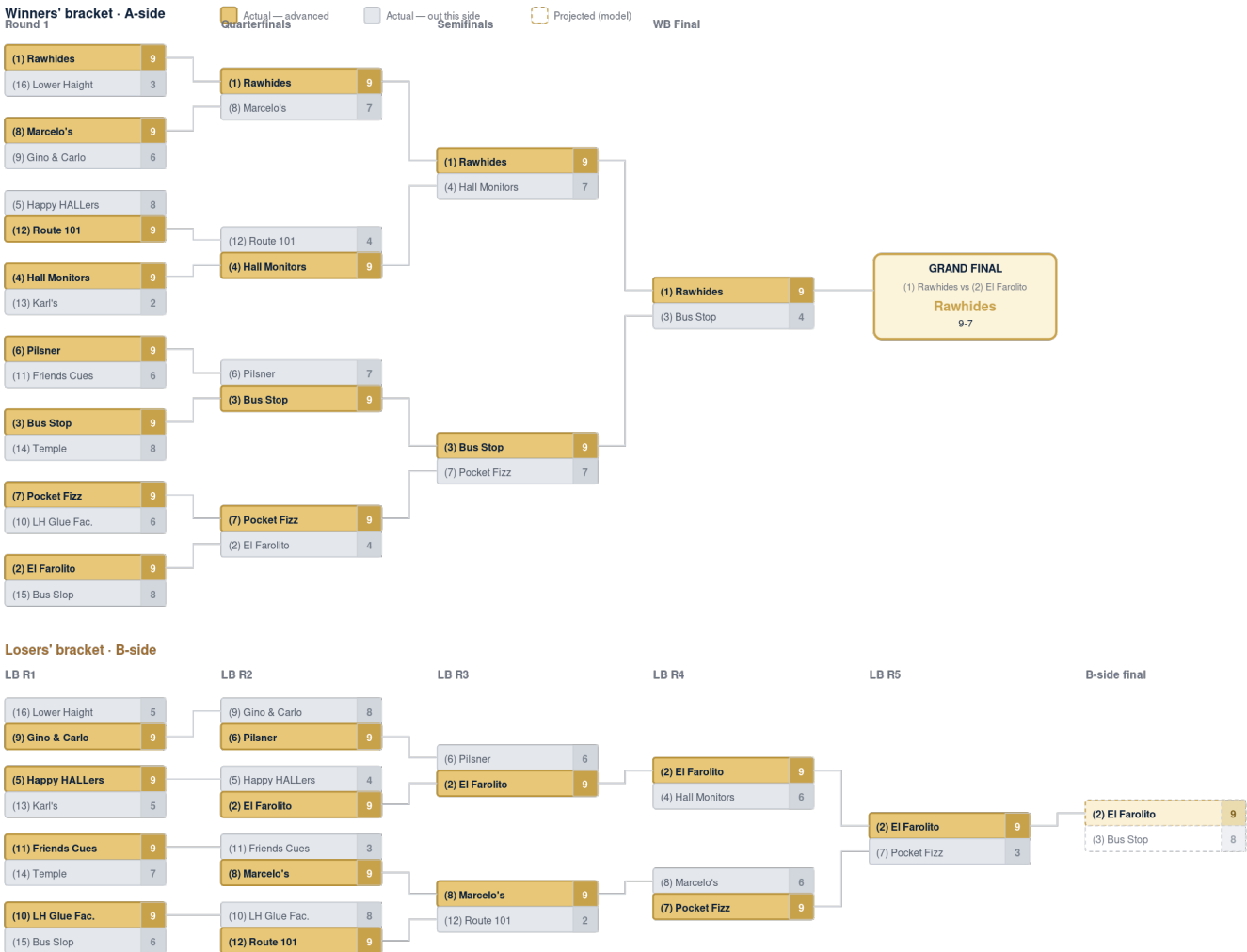
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**Rawhides** are the favorite to win the City Championship at **91%**, ahead of a tight chase between **El Farolito** (6%) and **Bus Stop** (3%). Together the top three hold about 100% of all title equity; below them the field falls off sharply.

| Team                         | Seed | Title % | Reach Grand Final |
|------------------------------|------|---------|-------------------|
| Happy Lounge Rawhides        | 1    | 91.1%   | 100%              |
| El Farolito Shooters         | 2    | 6.4%    | 59%               |
| Bus Stop Flyers              | 3    | 2.5%    | 41%               |
| Hall Monitors                | 4    | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Happy HALLers                | 5    | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Pilsner InnDecisives         | 6    | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Pocket Full of Fizz          | 7    | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Marcelo's Hall Stars         | 8    | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Gino & Carlo                 | 9    | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory | 10   | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Friends Crooked Cues         | 11   | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Route 101 Dalmatians         | 12   | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Karl's Freakin' Beacon       | 13   | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Temple Holy Smokes           | 14   | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Bus Slop                     | 15   | 0.0%    | 0%                |
| Lower Haight Misfits         | 16   | 0.0%    | 0%                |

# Projected Bracket

Single most-likely path through the 16-team double elimination. Lose on the A-side (winners') and you drop to the B-side (losers'); a second loss ends your run. The B-side survivor must beat the A-side finalist twice. **Grand Final:** (1) Rawhides vs (2) El Farolito — champion **Rawhides** (9-7).



## The state of play

For all the model's confidence in the favorite, this has been the opposite of a chalk tournament. Rawhides have held up their end — a commanding **91.1%** to win it — but everything behind them has been chaos: a #2 seed knocked out early, the six-season Pilsner dynasty gone, a 12-seed Cinderella in Route 101, and a 7-seed in Pocket Fizz that flatly refused to read the seed lines before finally going out. With the field down to **3**, the two brackets have collapsed into a single storyline: who gets a shot at the top seed, and can they actually take it.

**Rawhides have already done the hard part** — they own the hot seat, won the winners'-bracket final, and now just wait with a Grand Final berth banked, needing to win a game just once more where everyone else needs it twice. Four seasons of history back the number: Rawhides are **5-1** all-time against Bus Stop and a perfect **2-0** in the playoffs. Everything else is happening on the one-loss side, where **El Farolito** and **Bus Stop** — the two teams still breathing behind the favorite — meet in the losers'-bracket final with a single ticket to the reset final on the line.

What keeps it tense even with a heavy favorite is the double-elimination math. Rawhides need just one more win and carry a safety net; whoever survives the losers' bracket has to beat them *twice in a row* with nothing left in reserve. One win with insurance versus two must-wins with none — that asymmetry is the whole tournament in a sentence. For the trophy to change hands, somebody's long shot has to hit twice.

# Last Round's Results: Winners' Bracket Final + Losers' Bracket R5

The winners'-bracket final is done, and it wasn't close: Rawhides dropped Bus Stop 9-4, punching a ticket straight to the grand final with the double-elimination cushion every team in this draw has been chasing since the seeds came out. The model had this coming — Rawhides was already a 79.2% favorite — but a win this size still moves the number: title odds jump to 91.1%, up 11.9 points from a week ago.

Look at the box score and the match tells its own story. For Rawhides, Kevin Scheper went a perfect 3-0, while across the table Bus Stop stayed in the fight early — Wade Hargrove led the way at 2-2. It caught up with them in the end, though: Justin Anderson never got on the board, going 0-3, and the bottom of the lineup is exactly where Rawhides bracket-favorite depth is supposed to show up.

The undercard carried its own gut-punch. El Farolito eliminated Pocket Fizz 9-3 to end their season, and Otoniel Jimenez went a perfect 3-0. The cruelest detail belongs to the losing side: Albert Yip and Clayton Lapointe were held scoreless, a combined 0-for-6 — on the night their season ended.

3 teams remain. Bus Stop drops to the losers'-bracket final to face El Farolito — the winner of that one earns a single shot at Rawhides, and it comes with the cruelest condition in the sport: a true reset, meaning they have to beat the top seed twice in a row to take the title.

| Result                               | Model predicted | Actual |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------|--------|
| (1) Rawhides def. (3) Bus Stop       | Rawhides 9-6    | 9-4    |
| (2) El Farolito def. (7) Pocket Fizz | El Farolito 9-6 | 9-3    |

Model-predicted score (favorite and expected margin) vs. the actual result. Shaded rows mark a match the model's pick lost; winner's game count shown first.

## Looking Ahead

### The losers'-bracket final — El Farolito vs Bus Stop

The one-loss bracket crowns its champion. El Farolito and Bus Stop both have exactly one path left, and it runs through each other first: win this and you earn the right to chase the top seed through a true-reset grand final — beating them twice in a row, with nothing in the bank. Lose, and the season's over tonight.

They've actually met once already, and it settled nothing. Back in the regular season, Bus Stop and El Farolito played to an 8-8 tie — dead level, 8 games apiece — the one result on the schedule that refused to pick a side. Now, with a season on the line and ties off the table (this is race-to-9, sudden death), somebody finally has to blink.

Both arrive hot off wins that tell very different stories. El Farolito bulldozed a way here off elimination games; Bus Stop just got run off the winners'-bracket floor by the top seed and now has to prove that loss was a blip, not a trend. The model gives El Farolito 59% for the match — 53% per game, effective Fargo 569 to 553 — but this bracket has made a habit of ignoring the model.

## Playoff Standouts

The bracket is a team game, but somebody has to make the balls. A look at who's carrying the load for the teams still standing — the players quietly (and not so quietly) winning their matches within the match.

### Standout of the round

No one has been better with the season on the line. Steven Waldon has gone **9-2** in the playoffs — a **82%** win rate, the best of any regular still standing. The winners'-bracket final was the first time all playoffs he's actually lost a rack in a match he still won — Bus Stop's Wade Hargrove caught him in the opener — but Waldon answered by running the table to beat Justin Anderson and closing it out again over Tom Purcell, going **2-1** as Rawhides put Bus Stop away 9-4 and walked into the grand final. That's the Waldon pattern: even his rare off-night still ends in a win. If the grand final ever comes down to a single deciding game, he's exactly who the Rawhides want stepping to the table.

| Player          | Team        | Playoff W-L | Win % | Table runs |
|-----------------|-------------|-------------|-------|------------|
| Steven Waldon   | Rawhides    | 9-2         | 82%   | 2          |
| Otoniel Jimenez | El Farolito | 12-6        | 67%   | 2          |
| Wade Hargrove   | Bus Stop    | 8-4         | 67%   | —          |
| Kevin Scheper   | Rawhides    | 9-5         | 64%   | —          |
| Bob Simon       | Rawhides    | 7-4         | 64%   | 1          |
| Tom Purcell     | Bus Stop    | 9-6         | 60%   | 1          |
| Perez Vallarta  | El Farolito | 8-6         | 57%   | 1          |
| Rene Loria      | Bus Stop    | 8-8         | 50%   | —          |

Individual game record across the playoff weeks, for players on teams still alive (min. 6 games). Table runs = racks won from the break without the opponent reaching the table.

**Hottest hands this week:** Otoniel Jimenez (El Farolito) 3-0; Kevin Scheper (Rawhides) 3-0.

## Playoff Performance Ratings

A performance rating answers a different question than a win-loss record: *how good did you actually play?* We take every individual game a player played this playoff run, look up each opponent's Fargo, and solve for the rating at which their win total is exactly what you'd expect. Beat a 500-rated player at a 4-2 clip and you performed like a 600. It rewards beating strong opponents and doesn't punish anyone for a tough draw — the ultimate opponent-adjusted scoreboard.

### Top performer — 759

And nobody in the tournament has played at a higher level than **Steven Waldon**. Against playoff competition averaging **542** Fargo, his 7-1 run computes to an **759 performance rating** — a staggering **+155 over his own 604 rating**, and the single highest performance mark of anyone in the field (the next-best is 730). Put plainly: a very good 604-rated player spent the playoffs playing like an elite 800+. That's not a hot streak against soft competition — his opponents averaged 542 — it's the best pool anyone in this City Championship has played.

| Player             | Team          | W-L  | Avg opp | Fargo | Performance | vs rating   |
|--------------------|---------------|------|---------|-------|-------------|-------------|
| Steven Waldon      | Rawhides      | 9-2  | 542     | 604   | <b>759</b>  | <b>+155</b> |
| Khanh Ngo          | Marcelo's     | 8-2  | 521     | 583   | <b>730</b>  | <b>+147</b> |
| Prithiv Kumar      | Hall Monitors | 9-2  | 487     | 544   | <b>719</b>  | <b>+175</b> |
| Antonio Cracchiolo | Hall Monitors | 8-2  | 492     | 578   | <b>707</b>  | <b>+129</b> |
| Joshua Maldonado   | Rawhides      | 3-1  | 535     | 591   | <b>695</b>  | <b>+104</b> |
| Wade Hargrove      | Bus Stop      | 8-4  | 542     | 552   | <b>644</b>  | <b>+92</b>  |
| Willie Gregory     | Marcelo's     | 5-2  | 478     | 561   | <b>616</b>  | <b>+55</b>  |
| Nithin Tharakan    | Marcelo's     | 9-5  | 512     | 525   | <b>601</b>  | <b>+76</b>  |
| Bob Simon          | Rawhides      | 7-4  | 505     | 543   | <b>591</b>  | <b>+48</b>  |
| Otoniel Jimenez    | El Farolito   | 12-6 | 489     | 627   | <b>589</b>  | <b>-38</b>  |
| Tom Purcell        | Bus Stop      | 9-6  | 524     | 515   | <b>583</b>  | <b>+68</b>  |
| Albert Yip         | Pocket Fizz   | 6-4  | 492     | 487   | <b>551</b>  | <b>+64</b>  |
| Perez Vallarta     | El Farolito   | 8-6  | 499     | 537   | <b>540</b>  | <b>+3</b>   |

Performance = the Fargo level a player performed at across the playoffs, from opponent-weighted results (players on teams still alive, min. 6 games). "vs rating" is performance minus their own Fargo.

## Team Elo — Overall Strength

Each team's strength rating: the Fargo of their best playoff lineup, adjusted for season form, plus a data-tested pedigree where earned. Higher = stronger. This is what drives the title odds.

| Rank | Team                         | Team Elo | Top-4 Fargo | Title % |
|------|------------------------------|----------|-------------|---------|
| 1    | Happy Lounge Rawhides        | 1702     | 609.5       | 91.1%   |
| 2    | Pilsner InnDecisives         | 1632     | 539.0       | 0.0%    |
| 3    | Hall Monitors                | 1620     | 567.0       | 0.0%    |
| 4    | El Farolito Shooters         | 1605     | 548.0       | 6.4%    |
| 5    | Marcelo's Hall Stars         | 1598     | 553.8       | 0.0%    |
| 6    | Bus Stop Flyers              | 1594     | 550.5       | 2.5%    |
| 7    | Pocket Full of Fizz          | 1526     | 515.0       | 0.0%    |
| 8    | Happy HALLers                | 1509     | 503.8       | 0.0%    |
| 9    | Temple Holy Smokes           | 1508     | 513.2       | 0.0%    |
| 10   | Gino & Carlo                 | 1502     | 505.2       | 0.0%    |
| 11   | Friends Crooked Cues         | 1454     | 478.0       | 0.0%    |
| 12   | Route 101 Dalmatians         | 1412     | 455.8       | 0.0%    |
| 13   | Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory | 1401     | 453.8       | 0.0%    |
| 14   | Bus Slop                     | 1378     | 443.2       | 0.0%    |
| 15   | Karl's Freakin' Beacon       | 1363     | 431.8       | 0.0%    |
| 16   | Lower Haight Misfits         | 1317     | 409.8       | 0.0%    |



## How These Numbers Were Built

**1. A rating based on who actually plays.** Each team is rated by its players' Fargo (skill) ratings — but performance is judged against the lineup it *actually fielded* each match, not its best-case roster. If a team rests a star or plays a weaker substitute who performs at their own level, the model doesn't punish them: it expected less, and got it. When a 405-rated depth player loses most of his games to 600-rated opponents, that's neutral, not a black mark. Most rating systems can't tell "played badly" from "fielded a weaker lineup" — this one can, because it reads every individual player's result in every match.

**2. Win probabilities — and proof they work.** Playoff matches are a race to 9 (a 9-3 match ends after 12 games). The Fargo gap between the two lineups sets each game's odds, capped at 75/25 since pool has too much variance for locks; at 8-8 a single deciding game is played between each team's top player. We back-tested the engine on this season: it correctly called **76.5% of 251 matches** (Brier score 0.154), with well-calibrated confidence — the basis for trusting the odds.

**3. 60,000 simulated tournaments.** The full double-elimination bracket is played 60,000 times; every number in this report — the title odds and the projected bracket — comes from that one simulation, so they're mutually consistent.

**4. A data-tested pedigree for Pilsner.** Rather than guess at a "dynasty" weight, we tested it: across four seasons of playoff results, Pilsner's record is 4-season playoff record 17-7 (71%), and every loss came against Rawhides — against everyone else they are a perfect 15-0. That overperformance is statistically real ( $p < 0.05$ ), so Pilsner carries a measured +30 Fargo playoff bump. No other team earned one; Rawhides' four titles are the best team doing what it should, already in its rating.

Every adjustment has a number behind it, not a feel. Pool is high-variance — treat these as probabilities, not predictions; even a clear favorite loses far more often than it wins.

## Appendix — Season Form

A supporting metric, not a strength rating: did a team beat or miss its own roster's Fargo expectation this season, match by match? A strong team can show negative form if it underplayed its talent.

| Team                         | Season Form | vs roster     |
|------------------------------|-------------|---------------|
| El Farolito Shooters         | +28.0       | overachieved  |
| Happy HALLers                | +17.2       | overachieved  |
| Route 101 Dalmatians         | +14.4       | overachieved  |
| Karl's Freakin' Beacon       | +13.9       | overachieved  |
| Friends Crooked Cues         | +11.6       | overachieved  |
| Lower Haight Misfits         | +10.8       | overachieved  |
| Pocket Full of Fizz          | +8.1        | overachieved  |
| Pilsner InnDecisives         | +4.9        | ~ as expected |
| Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory | +4.0        | ~ as expected |
| Bus Stop Flyers              | +3.5        | ~ as expected |
| Gino & Carlo                 | +2.4        | ~ as expected |
| Bus Slop                     | +1.6        | ~ as expected |
| Marcelo's Hall Stars         | +0.1        | ~ as expected |
| Hall Monitors                | -7.3        | underachieved |
| Happy Lounge Rawhides        | -10.4       | underachieved |

| Team               | Season Form | vs roster     |
|--------------------|-------------|---------------|
| Temple Holy Smokes | -13.5       | underachieved |